

ETHICS OF DWELLING

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Introduction

Dwelling in Metadesign

Starting from the simple idea that space designs us, where “us” stands for dwellers subscribing to various motivations of dwelling, we may draw a line towards the possibility of dwelling being in itself a physical and psychological manifestation of co-living. The relationship between dwellers and space may be often assigned by the structural development of the urban and rural living environments, as well as to the very extent of metaphysical interpretation experienced by one or more individuals.

Before going as further as the metaphysical aspect of co-living surroundings, we may explore some rather more tangible levels of space comprehension. In this text, we take as examples within this spectrum of dwelling tangibility three strategies of assigned dwelling, starting from the Autobahn bridges between New York and Long Island, as an example of designing dwellers outside of Long Island; jumping towards a possibly reversed approach to the previously mentioned, Jubileumsparken, more concretely the spaces assigned for the public’s sake of dwelling in healthy and creative manners; and before drawing a conclusion we will elaborate on the importance of culturally and politically charged artifacts gathered and replanted outside of their context, yet conglomerating a new set of relations of their own between dwellers and arguably radical co-living, as supported by

the project Superkilen, which may invite us closer to considering the potential of relating metadesign and metaphysics. This sort of spectrum journey comes as a structural exploration of several types of ethical and political implications within dwelling and metadesign.

Robert Moses’ Low Bridges

In the first part of this text we will follow Winner’s take on the low bridges of Robert Moses, as his view on material technical artefacts is that they are intrinsically political. He mentions that “tangible artefacts, including the built environment and other material-space arrangements embody ‘social’ (that is, ‘power’) relations. (Joerges, 1999) “Do Artefacts Have Politics” affords an extensive back-and-forth of arguments regarding the political investment of the low bridges, as far as furthering from the tangible form of the bridges somewhat completely, while allocating more importance to the debate itself. Plenty paragraphs argue between the political implications as either purposefully implemented or resulting from a snowball effect of the previously designed infrastructure of New York and Long Island, that led to ultimately forming a structurally induced disadvantageous commuting situation between the city and the resort. Having in mind Winner’s statement on power relationships, saying that “one must build a wall if one wants to prevent others from passing

through”, we may follow the idea that no design decision is stranded from power relationships, and no design decision is apolitical. If the bridges do keep black people and the poor strata from reaching Long Island, it may very well come to a point of consensus where we can all see the direct effects of such design decisions, even if initially they may have not been interrogated thoroughly. Considering the temporality of artefacts, we may question the aftermath of a design decision and also how we relate to it. Do we come back to a faulty design to try fixing it or do we “fix” our own perspective towards the certain artefact? A shorter question would be: does space design us? This question comes from Willis’ reading of Heidegger, in “Ontological Designing”, as “if we pervade buildings, they also pervade us - entrances, corridors, stairs, lifts, large rooms, small rooms - all design our modes of spatial occupation and our movements through spaces, allowing some, not allowing others.” (Willis, 2006)

Is it worth considering that Moses planned the bridges in 1925, as a matter of city planning accuracy in regards of metadesign strategies or is it rather to be looked at as an opportunity for planning people out of Long Island due to insufficient regulations and potential purposefully planned segregation? We can look at it as a knot of problems, since it does not only create direct problems, but also potential new problems in relation to this root problem. We can at least use it for the very moment as an example of metadesign against inclusion, which we now depart from and towards inclusive contemporary metadesign city planning.

Jubileumsparken

Sandström brings a direct reading into the ethics of care and the ethics of affect in “Learning to Care, Learning to Be Affected: Two Public Spaces Designed to Counter Segregation”, borrowing feminist scholar Puig de la Bellacasa’s take on what caring stands for in the realm of space making, having the word “care” as a twofold: “the affectionate connection to the space on the one hand, and the labour of caretaking on the other hand.” As Sandström puts it, Jubileumsparken invites people to connect with the spaces in this dual sense, asking its visitors to care about the space, but also to take care of the space by investing work into it - following the belief that the level of commitment will increase proportionally with the time and work invested in a space.” (Sandström, 2020) The dwellers have the opportunity to show care for Jubileumsparken by making use of the space both as it is already assigned through projects like the pools, the sauna, and the urban garden, but also through potential new projects and creative endeavours that the public requires, requests, and initiate. Here dwelling and co-living comes in a somewhat more digestible form than what we have discussed previously, since the dwellers are encouraged to perform practical and therefore fundamentally physical acts of expanding their dwelling expressions. Jubileumsparken is design both for and with the public. I believe, the temporality of the umbrella project allows fluidity and interchangeability. It is not meant as fixed, while not necessarily being a project

laboratory. I bring “fixed” and “laboratory” into light as industrial representations of result-oriented strategies of city planning. A shape-shifting body of space may relate even more with dwellers, either as a personification of space or as a more approachable and democratic space-defining practice. “Thing-ing with things” can work as a driver for allocating strictly implement order of dwelling spaces, but in a reciprocal approach, we may as well keep spaces alive and relatable, sculpting a more animated mirror of what dwelling means. (Willis, 2006) Therefore I ask, is dwelling forever-lasting or forever-changing?

Superkilen

Superkilen consists of several hyper-present objects from around the world, either related to eviction and migration or rather related to tourism and adventure. Examples being the bull from Spain, soil from Palestine, Kurdish benches, and an elephant slide from Pripyat. Some politically charged artefacts may generate a certain level of provocation at the site. Sandström points out that “at Superkilen, we do not only co-exist, but we coexist together.” (Sandström, 2020) Elements that may inspire anger and anxiety, not only curiosity and learning opportunities, allow round experiences of space and therefore shared personal co-living discrepancies. Being affected, Sandström argues, is as well a method of caring. I believe, coming from Sanström’s view, that one allows oneself to be affected when one cares

for; in other words, one cares to be exposed, hurt, disagreed with, thought, confronted, comforted. In Superkilen’s example the dweller is challenged (at the same time with other dwellers of different origins and especially opinions) to dwell back. Dwelling can be hard or easy regarding how compatible one is with the already existing dwelling space, yet in a city like Copenhagen, differences are often what people have in common, being it intergenerational or regarding origins and traditions. A city of different dwellers may as well provide dwelling spaces accordingly to the very aspect of difference in a positive and informational sense, even at the expense of temporary intrigue.

It is hard for me to label Superkilen as an open-air museum or cultural exhibition, since it is foremost, I believe, a public space designed for co-living and co-feeling. Putting the difference upfront may be practiced with good intentions, yet it could be a difficult approach at the same time, there are no shortcuts for inclusion. “Superkilen is a space that plays with the very idea that an object or an event in one place can affect objects and events in other places, but it is also a space made to affect its visitors emotionally - and the two processes, to affect and to be affected, are here inherently interconnected.”

Here, I imagine, we have gotten somewhat closer to the threshold between the physical and the metaphysical metadesign strategies of city planning. By which ([I guess] I believe) I mean, that a metaphysical knot is generated right in front of our eyes by the artificial etherical simulation of space cognition and space comprehension. We read

space, and we read ourselves through the space we dwell in. Also, we read ourselves in the thin metaphysical relations between our dwelling spaces. We read ourselves in what we comprehend, and also in what we do not comprehend. We read ourselves in what we do and do not believe. We read ourselves in problems and solutions. We read ourselves in decisions, in design. We design to design ourselves. Design is dwelling. Design is not comfort, because design is dwelling. We co-exist, therefore we co-live or we co-dwell. ([I guess] I believe, of course)

Children in Urban Environments

Finally, we get off the flimsy metatrain. Time to rest a bit, because we are about go all the way back to Tangibleville. I may have an unorthodox structure by bringing one of the core elements of this text so late in the picture, but I hope I can support this decision. Let us talk about children in urban environments and see how, supposedly, the first approximately 1500 words work as a ramp, getting steeper and steeper towards the last paragraphs, until it almost ironically becomes a vertical threshold towards a (not particularly) academic axis mundi. If at this point we release the breaks of our metatrain and let it run backwards we have the opportunity to watch through the windows of the metatrain a flashing collection of imaginary still-frames of the children’s role and presence throughout this journey.

Having in mind that “children are important allies in the shaping of a sustainable urban future provided they get access to an environment in which they can develop their competence and commitment. [...] their perspectives also depend on the specific circumstances of their local community,” we can almost see a decline in children’s engagement and agency, but also play affordances, starting from brighter and more creative examples as Superkilen and Jubileumsparken, and slowly fading throughout the bridges example we started from. (Mårtensson and Nordström, 2017)

- Joerges, B. (1999) “Do Politics Have Artefacts?,” *Social studies of science*, 29(3), pp. 411–431.

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- Sandström, I. (2020) “Learning to Care, Learning to Be Affected: Two Public Spaces Designed to Counter Segregation,” *Urban planning*, 5(4), pp. 171–182.

- Mårtensson, F, Nordström, M. (2017) “Nordic child friendly urban planning reconsidered,” Chapter 3, pp. 1-11